Germany's division and American history. Freed, Davis, Tajiri, and Lorde went to Berlin for different reasons but made the city a point of habitual return, after each found spaces of illumination and epiphany in varied corners of the divided city. They rendered their experiences in an array of creative productions that are distinguished by respective interdisciplinary formats, intended audiences, critical methodologies, and historical contexts of distribution. And yet they shared a profound sense of being both haunted and at home in Berlin, a balance they negotiated to present powerful works crucial to understandings of American culture. They coproduced a critical American tradition of engagement with the Berlin Wall and continue to evoke perspectives across multiple sites of U.S.-sponsored global freedom and repression. Four individuals set against an evolving history, they represent and stand in for a legion of others who also set foot in some of the most traumatized and divided spaces, whether in Berlin or elsewhere, as a means to remediate those places and transform themselves. Together, they remind us that the movement of history and the geographies of division cannot be scripted without space for intervention, reckoning, co-creation, and resistance.

We may never fully heed the lessons of previous generations of wall builders, whose historic constructions viciously divided societies, inhumanely practiced separation of families and neighbors, and left far-reaching destruction in their paths. Once these dividing walls are brought down, their ruins stand only as brutal, unintentional monuments to their own eventual demise. We can, however, continue to learn from artists, writers, and activists who have for generations approached dividing walls to pivot toward greater forms of interaction and acknowledgment and hasten the dismantling of repressive borders and social structures. This includes both the physical and social structures we encounter each day. As such, the mantle of the critical work on the Berlin Wall by Freed, Davis, Tajiri, Lorde, and others, carried out in response to physical and social boundaries in Berlin, the United States, and elsewhere, is brought forward by a new generation of cultural figures, who continue to approach sites of injustice and transform them into spaces of fuller freedoms, whether at the U.S. border, the walls of our criminal justice system, the institutional barriers made visible through intersectional feminist and queer organizing, transnational sites of apartheid and migration, or other spaces of repression.